

Forest fungi

Scientists place fungi into a separate group, or “kingdom,” of living things because fungi are neither plants nor animals. The mushroom or toadstool you see is only a tiny part of a much bigger organism that is one of nature’s great recyclers.

Beneficial bracket

A shelflike growth on a tree is called a bracket fungus. Most bracket fungi appear only on dead or dying trees. Apart from breaking down rotting wood, they also provide food for other creatures.



Dead-wood dweller

Golf ball-shaped fungi found on a rotting stump or fallen branch are most likely stump puffballs. When touched, the balls release clouds of tiny spores—each of which can become a new puffball fungus.

Deadly destroyers

Some fungi harm forests. The honey fungus attacks trees underground, killing the roots of both conifers and deciduous trees. By the time mushrooms appear on their trunk, the trees are already doomed.

